



speaker test

A speaker is also called an "electroacoustical transducer" that converts an electrical signal to sound



Audio Engine A2

preferred the darker, timeless mahogany look that some very expensive audiophile gear boasts off, these have a slightly lighter colour that nonetheless looks classy. The enclosures are unnecessarily large, a fact which was reinforced when we heard them. On a tackier note (and a gross violation of design appeal), the frequency response graph plotted out in white text on a black background on the front of the left speaker unit just looks cheap. As do the volume, bass and treble controls — they're buttons! These speakers are heavy and large enough for most users to place them on the floor making the tiny control buttons on the bottom part of the front bezel an ergonomic goof up. As attractive as these speakers look, we'd really like if the enclosures were smaller in size. That being said, the drivers look well done with a brushed metal and chrome finish. Build quality is very good.

The Artis S7+ was the next speaker we looked at. These were tiny compared to the ZEB-T9000 and largely for someone looking at a very entry-level speaker for very low volume listening. Their build quality wasn't bad, but it's nothing worth writing home about. The Altec Lansing FX 2020 unit has a transparent dark fibre body that most people will find funky. The speakers themselves are cylindrical and the front has a large bezel-like square portion with which these can rest on any surface without rolling around. Build quality is good as is the quality of materials used and the connectors. The Audio Engine 2 was the next candidate under our magnifying glass. This is a piano-white finished unit that is small, but manages to look impressive nonetheless. The speakers themselves have Kevlar used for the cones and everything looks built very well. These speakers have the option to connect them to an additional woofer unit, which is a plus for anyone looking for more bass. The quality of connecting wires is absolutely top class.

Performance:

Although one does not expect a great movie experience sans a woofer unit, we were surprised to see the oodles of sound quality and quantity on offer. The Artis S7+ is the minnow of the lot and it shows as its performance can best be described as poor. There was no bass to speak of and the mid-range and highs were both rather crippled. However, it wasn't as bad as we'd expected

when we saw the poor little things atop our test desk, we had expected much worse. The Altec Lansing FX 2020 was the next disappointment and frankly we were expecting a lot more from these speakers and the Altec Lansing brand. Sound quality is good *per se* and the FX 2020 gives reasonable bass for its size. The mid-range output is good; good guitaring and vocals come across well, especially Guns N' Roses where Axel Rose's screaming high notes are reproduced well. However, once the volume is turned up more than half way the ordeal begins, and everything is horribly distorted. In fact, at 80 per cent or above volumes all but aurally impaired will want to run out of the room and never look back. The Zebronic ZEB T-9000 impressed us at first, but not as much as we'd expected given their classy looks. They lack bass which we expected for a four-inch driver unit, but we had expected a little more than the loose and ineffectual bass they reproduced. The mid-range is rich and the vocals come across really well. There is depth to both male and female vocals that is pleasing to the ears and guitar passages are really enjoyable. At times, the T-9000 gets rather bright and this was noticeable during the

track *Everybody Hurts* by The Corrs — the vocals and cymbals come across as being a little too crisp to be termed as natural. The Audio Engine A2 was the last speaker we looked at. Although we were hoping to receive the A5 as well, which is a higher-end model that is more powerful than the A2, we were initially blown away by the power of the A2s. For such a small speaker system they are quite powerful, although sadly they distort at volume levels beyond 70 per cent of their maximum. The mid-range is clear and precise and the vocals have a very rich tone to them that feels satisfying. A lot of the guitar plucking during Eric Clapton's *Tears In Heaven* sounded almost like the guitar was being strung in front of us. Although the A5 will perform even better since it has a larger mid-range driver, we feel what the A2 really needs is a companion to help through the lower frequencies — which is its one weakness. You can see the tiny drivers trying their best to produce bass and the bass is noticeable, but not as focused and punchy as we would like. With its sterling performance throughout the mid-range the A2 captured our hearts; in fact, the only area it was best was the movie tests where the Zebronic ZEB T-9000 produced more bass, although not essentially better bass.

Winners:

Our best buy was the Zebronic ZEB T-9000 for its superb price-to-performance ratio. Sure the Audio Engine A2 was a better performer at one-fourth the size of the



Zebronic Duality 6000